AGRICULTURAL PROSPECTS

Both Arab and Jewish agriculture have made great progress during the past quarter century. Yet, even in the best years, the Arab peasant has enjoyed a standard of living that is good only in contrast with the brutish poverty common in the Arab Middle East. Even the Jewish farmer has as yet achieved only a very modest manner of living, by Western standards.

The Arab farmer is turning away from subsistance farming toward supplying urban markets. His agriculture differs from that of a quarter century ago in placing less emphasis on the low-yielding cereals and more on the vegetables, fruits and olives that are better adapted to his soil and climate. He has relatively fewer sheep and goats and more cattle and poultry. Wartime inflation has freed him, perhaps for the first time in centuries, from a burden of debt that amounted often almost to debt slavery.

The Arab farmer still needs a land reform that will give a consolidated, workable holding. He needs cheap Government credit to enable him, over many years, to acquire clean title to the land. He needs irrigation and training in the care of irrigated cultures. A reasonable goal to improve his position during the next decade might involve semi-intensive development of an additional 125,000 acres of irrigated land for Arab diversified farming, a further growth of about 70 percent (22,500 acres) in Arab citriculture, and a modest beginning (4,250 acres) with other export crops. The farm capital required for these purposes would be about £P 16.5 million ($66 million).

With the improvement of the productivity of Arab farms must come a steady reduction in the percentage of the Arab labor force employed in agriculture. The Arab farm community already suffers from a solid core of underemployment, which cannot be reduced in a manner compatible with steadily rising per capita income except by the expansion of urban occupations.

Jewish agriculture has won solid ground after great hardship, underequipped, working with a labor force previously without experience in farming and on land much of which was formerly regarded